Extended essay: commentary for example essay			
DP subject: (Subject-focused essay)			
DP subjects: (Interdisciplinary essay)	**Geography and Economics**	Interdisciplinary framework:	**Power, equality, justice**
Research question:	How effective are microfinance institutions in reducing gender inequalities in low-income countries?		
Assessment details			
Criterion:	Mark awarded:	Commentary: (Incorporating wording from the assessment criteria)	
A: Framework for the essay [Maximum possible mark: 6]	**4**	The research question is clear and focused, and relevant to the topic, though ambitious for a 4000-word essay. Suitable secondary research methods are used but are not always fully explained and applied. Structural conventions are used which support communication of the research, especially in the early part of the essay which shows good alignment with the aims of the interdisciplinary pathway. However, referencing is occasionally incomplete and the use of many short paragraphs appears to inhibit depth of discussion, making the essay appear overly structured. The best fit mark is four.	
B: Knowledge and understanding [Maximum possible mark: 6]	**4**	Relevant research materials are used to establish knowledge of the topic and area of research. A literature search has been conducted with the results sifted for relevance. Terminology from the chosen DP subjects is used accurately, conveying a sense of wider understanding. Relatively few concepts are used from both DP subjects and in this sense the essay appears to lack depth. However, the subject matter is extensive. The best fit mark is four.	
C: Analysis and line of argument [Maximum possible mark: 6]	**4**	The Essay includes partially effective analysis with relevant findings. The heavily structured approach and inclusion of two case studies limits depth of analysis. The line of argument established is that microfinance takes several forms, with one form proving economically beneficial to women in Bangladesh. However social benefits to the status of women remain contested. In Pakistan, limits to the social status of women and microfinance institutions themselves conspire to prevent social and economic advancement. Attention to the line of argument is	

		sustained, though the case study of Pakistan seems to contribute relatively less. The best fit mark is four.
D: Discussion and evaluation [Maximum possible mark: 8]	**6**	The studies considered support a balanced discussion of the topic, more in the case study of Bangladesh than Pakistan. Attempts to evaluate the findings and contribution of the essay are made towards the end, including valuable awareness that conclusions are limited by the availability and possible partiality of the studies considered and selection bias. In the conclusion the author returns to the global perspective of the introduction, putting the contribution of the case studies in context as both limited yet valid. It is argued that he systemic barriers to gender equality are only partially undermined by microfinance in particular circumstances, and this is a good evaluative conclusion consistent with the evidence presented. The best fit mark is six
E: Reflection [Maximum possible mark: 4]	**3**	The student does reflect on and attempts to evaluate the learning experience. A rationale for the topic is provided, as well as a deepening sense of engagement as the research question is refined. Growth and transfer of learning is reflected in overcoming the challenges of organising sustained research and writing, and realising the power of analysis and global consciousness
Total marks awarded	21 /30	
Holistic comment on the essay:	Microfinance and gender equality are at the confluence of DP Geography and Economics so this is a suitable if modestly challenging topic for an interdisciplinary Essay. The student takes a methodical approach which sometimes lacks analytical and evaluative depth, and referencing is occasionally inconsistent or sparse. The influence of learning from the two DP subjects seems to dwindle somewhat after the strong introduction, but is compensated for by strong and evaluative concluding pages.	